Chapter 0

A Little Restaurant at the End of the Day

"You don't have to know what you want to eat. Sometimes, you just need someone to listen."

There was a little restaurant tucked away on a quiet street, somewhere between a laundromat that never seemed to close and a convenience store that sold terrible coffee.

It wasn't particularly famous.

It had no fancy decorations, no celebrity chef, and certainly no online reservation system. Its wooden tables were slightly scratched, its chairs didn't match, and one of the ceiling lights had been flickering for the past three years.

The owner kept promising to fix it.

He never did.

The restaurant opened every evening at six and stayed open until the last customer went home. Its sign was small, its windows glowed with warm yellow light, and the smell of freshly cooked food often drifted onto the sidewalk, tempting tired pedestrians to stop by.

Most of its customers arrived after work.

Office workers with loosened ties. Nurses with aching feet. Delivery drivers with rain-soaked jackets. Students who had spent too many hours studying and too little time sleeping. People who had missed their trains, lost their umbrellas, or simply didn't feel like going home to an empty apartment.

They were ordinary people, living ordinary lives.

And most of them were hungry.

But there was something unusual about the restaurant.

It had no menu.

Instead, a small handwritten sign sat beside the entrance.

COME IN. SIT DOWN. TELL ME ABOUT YOUR DAY.

That was all.

No prices were displayed. No daily specials were announced. And whenever a new customer sat at the counter and asked what they could order, the chef would give them the same answer.

"Nothing."

Naturally, this confused people.

"Nothing?"

"Nothing you need to choose, anyway."

"Then what am I supposed to eat?"

The chef would smile, wipe his hands on his apron, and point toward the empty stool beside the counter.

"Tell me about your day first."

Some customers thought it was a joke. Others assumed the man was a little strange. A few even stood up to leave, convinced that they had accidentally wandered into some kind of eccentric cooking show.

But the hungry ones usually stayed.

And sooner or later, they began to talk.

They talked about terrible bosses, broken relationships, missed opportunities, embarrassing mistakes, and dreams they had almost forgotten. Some talked for hours. Others managed only a few sentences before falling silent, staring at the countertop as if the wood grain contained the answers to all their problems.

The chef never pushed them to explain.

He simply listened.

Then he turned toward the kitchen.

And he cooked.

For the office worker who had spent an entire day being blamed for someone else's mistakes, he might prepare a bowl of steaming ramen, rich with broth and topped with a perfectly cooked egg.

For the young woman who had just moved to the city and missed her mother's cooking, he might make the simplest homemade meal imaginable, prepared exactly the way she remembered it.

For the elderly man who came in every Thursday and insisted that he wasn't particularly hungry, the chef always prepared two portions of whatever was on the stove.

One for the man.

And one for the wife he had lost five years ago.

Nobody knew how the chef managed to get it right.

He claimed it was experience.

His regular customers suspected witchcraft.

The chef refused to comment on the matter.

After all, he was a cook, not a magician.

At least, that was what he told everyone.

Over time, the little restaurant developed its own peculiar reputation. People came for the food, returned for the conversations, and eventually brought their friends, colleagues, and family members.

Some arrived laughing.

Some arrived crying.

Some came simply because they had forgotten what it felt like to sit somewhere without being expected to accomplish anything.

And every night, the chef served them a meal they had never ordered.

Because hunger came in many forms.

Sometimes, people needed something warm in their stomachs.

Sometimes, they needed to remember a happier time.

Sometimes, they needed the courage to take the first step toward something new.

And sometimes, they just needed someone to tell them that tomorrow could wait until morning.

The chef understood this better than most.

He had spent years learning how to cook, but it had taken him much longer to learn how to listen. He had his own reasons for opening the restaurant, his own regrets, and his own unfinished story tucked away somewhere behind the kitchen door.

But he rarely spoke about himself.

He preferred to let his customers do the talking.

Besides, there was always another bowl to prepare, another plate to wash, and another exhausted stranger standing outside the window, wondering whether they should come in.

Tonight would be no different.

At six o'clock, the sign was turned to OPEN.

At six fifteen, the first customer arrived.

At six twenty, someone complained about the weather.

At six thirty, a man in an expensive suit began explaining why he had just quit his job.

And at seven, a young woman walked through the door, sat down at the counter, and asked the chef a question he had never heard before.

"Do you ever get tired of listening to other people's problems?"

For the first time that evening, the chef stopped chopping vegetables.

He looked at her.

Then he laughed.

"Of course."

She blinked. "Really?"

"I'm human, aren't I?"

"Then why do you keep doing it?"

The chef glanced toward the kitchen, where a pot of soup simmered gently on the stove. Outside, the city lights flickered against the darkening windows, and somewhere down the street, a train sounded its arrival.

He thought about the question for a moment.

Then he placed a small bowl of warm soup in front of her.

"Because," he said, "everyone deserves at least one good thing at the end of a difficult day."

The young woman looked down at the bowl.

Steam curled gently into the air.

For a little while, neither of them said anything.

Then she picked up her spoon.

And began to tell him her story.

Outside, the city continued to rush toward tomorrow.

Inside, there was no hurry at all.

Welcome to the restaurant.

Tonight's menu is whatever your heart needs.